Three Mistakes Families Make When Lining Up Help for a Husband's Next Care Arrangement

Three assumptions to check before the plan rests on them.

When help is being lined up in a hurry, three assumptions tend to slip into a family's plan. They come from trust and tiredness, not carelessness, and each one can be checked with a pen.

1 Assuming help will be available

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE Your son says he'll come by. A neighbor says to call anytime. Your daughter, two hours away, says she'll drive down whenever you need her. The plan in your head has all three of them in it, and none of them has named a day.

WHY IT HAPPENS Families are right to count on each other: about 80 percent of care at home is provided by unpaid caregivers. But an offer is made in a warm moment, and asking for days and times can feel like doubting it, so nobody asks. [1]

> **WHAT TO DO INSTEAD** Ask each person which days, which hours and for how long. The Family Caregiver Alliance says that when you break the jobs down into very simple tasks, it is easier for people to help. Write down what is confirmed, and keep a general offer on its own line until it has a day and a time. [2]

2 Overlooking overnight coverage

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE The week is planned from breakfast to supper. Mornings have a name and afternoons have a name. The hours between bedtime and breakfast aren't on the page at all, because you'll be there.

WHY IT HAPPENS Plans get made in daylight, around daytime tasks. Whoever sleeps in the house is counted as covering the night without anyone having said so.

> **WHAT TO DO INSTEAD** Put the night on the page as its own block, with a name beside it like any other. The Family Caregiver Alliance suggests asking the discharge team directly: does he need help at night and, if so, how will I get enough sleep? Whether he needs someone overnight is their question to answer. Yours is to ask it. [3]

3 Asking one caregiver to provide support they cannot sustain

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE Every hour nobody else has taken ends up beside your name. Nobody decided that. It was what was left over, and you said yes the way you always have.

WHY IT HAPPENS A plan tends to assume the main caregiver can do whatever remains. AARP's planning guide says it plainly: caring for a family member or friend can be too big of a job for one person. [4]

> **WHAT TO DO INSTEAD** Add up the hours beside your name and say the number out loud to someone. Then tell the discharge staff what you can keep up and what you can't; the Family Caregiver Alliance says it is extremely important to tell them about a caregiver's limitations. Your limits are part of the picture the care team needs. They aren't a weakness in it. [3]

One habit covers all three

Put a name, a day and a time beside every part of the week, your own name included. Take the hours you can't fill, and the questions you can't answer, to the care team.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't say how much help your husband needs, whether his nights need covering, or whether the arrangement is safe. It names three assumptions, the same three the Family Care Roadmap sees at this step.

Ready for the next step?

You know which three assumptions to check. The care interview goes on from there: it asks about your husband's needs, his safety and each person who helps, one area at a time, and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

The figure on unpaid care, AARP's line about one person, and the Family Caregiver Alliance's advice come from the sources below. The three mistakes are the Family Care Roadmap's own.

1. Administration for Community Living, Who Will Provide Your Care?
2. Family Caregiver Alliance, Taking Care of YOU: Self-Care for Family Caregivers
3. Family Caregiver Alliance, Hospital Discharge Planning: A Guide for Families and Caregivers
4. AARP, Prepare to Care: A Planning Guide for Families

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